Speculation buzzes around how Kharat's revelations about his VIP clients would play out in echelons of power. The first scalp: NCP women's wing president Rupali Chakankar. She headed the state women's commission, but washed Kharat's feet. Photos and videos show her in reverential aspect; she even likened him to Lord Vithoba.

The Opposition points fingers at more leaders from the ruling Mahayuti. Shiv Sena (UBT) leader Sushma Andhare says former education minister Deepak Kesarkar, of deputy CM Eknath Shinde's Sena, be probed. Like Chakankar, he, too, pleads innocence. "So many people met him, around 39 MLAs. Why am I being named?" he asks. Andhare has also questioned Shinde's links with Kharat.

Takeaways

- **Victim tales end rape godman's reign of fear**
- **Ashok Kharat's sorcery had a wide VIP client base**

CM Devendra Fadnavis backs the acquaintance-is-not-guilt line. "We won't shield anyone, but can't book anyone just because they have been photographed (with Kharat)," he says. A judicious point: there are photos of Kharat with a gallery of BJP bigwigs, from Fadnavis to Union home minister Amit Shah.

The discomfiture will be evenly spread. A BJP minister allocated funds to Kharat's trust in 2018. The Uddhav Thackeray regime allocated it water from a dam. The Maharashtra Andhashraddha Nirmulan Samiti, a rationalist outfit, had long been on Kharat's trail for at least two decades, but the veil proved too thick, including when a top cabinet minister made a sudden visit to his temple in 2022. ■

▶ RAJASTHAN

Rajasthan Cricket Makes a Royal Mess

For long a playground for petty politics, a replay confirms the state is out to a hit-wicket once again

By **Rohit Parihar**

DAYS AGO, RAJASTHAN ROYALS had made waves with one of the richest deals in cricket: a reported $1.63 billion (Rs 15,250 crore). So, the poverty of governance in state cricket showed through starkly when, on March 29, a futile stirring of turbid waters left the Rajasthan Cricket Association (RCA) exactly what it was: a club for political satraps and their scions. The ad hoc committee running the RCA was reshuffled a ninth time, failing a ninth time to transform it. Out went convenor D.D. Kumawat, a BJP MLA. Elevated in his place was a former BJP MP's son, Mohit Yadav. He was already a member, with party scions like Dhananjay Singh and Ashish Tiwari; they now have company in new recruits Arjun Beniwal and Arisht Singhvi, also BJP dynasts.

Of late, the RCA has been steadily eroded as it became a playground for rivalries within the ruling BJP. The crisis makes a material difference. Jaipur, once a regular IPL venue, was missing from the initial schedule of 20 matches this season; it got only a handful of games in the later phase. The city also does not figure in the international calendar released so far.

NIGHT WATCHMEN STAY

This is a direct outcome of administrative paralysis: the ad hoc panel, originally tasked with conducting RCA elections within three months, has continued for over two years. Elections remain stalled, and authority is split between the RCA and the Rajasthan State Sports Council (RSSC), with Rajasthan Royals often pitching in to tilt the scales. Leader





EYE OF THE STORM Union sports minister Rajyavardhan Singh; former RCA head Vaibhav Gehlot